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votes to teach the Government a lesson. It doesn't mean that we have any political bias. But Christians have to strengthen their vote banks," says Archbishop Joseph Powathil, who is leading the agitation. He has even made a call to all Christian families to send their children only to Christian-run schools. Catholic leaders have also written to All India Congress Committee President Sonia Gandhi, ex-

pressing anguish over the alleged anti-Christian attitude of state Government. "Entrusting the administration of our schools to the local self-governments is a clear way of meddling with them politically," says Powathil.

Though Achuthanandan and CPI(M) Secretary Pinarayi Vijayan have warned minority leaders against playing political games with them, the Government looks alarmed as the

minority agitation is reminiscent of the minority-backed "liberation struggle", which had ousted the first Communist government in 1957. The Government leaders are bending over backwards saying there would be no move against minority-run institutions. "We have no plan to take over private or minority-run institutions," says Achuthanandan.

C.P. Nair, former chief secretary who heads the expert committee, says it will have none of the dreaded recommendations. "We don't want to change the school timings or to make boys and girls to sit together. All we are thinking of is having an attendance register in alphabetical order instead of the present gender-based registers". The committee is to submit its report, which contains various recommendations to improve administrative rules and the quality of education, to the Government by year end.

Although religious sentiments have been invoked by the minorities, the Government and those who support the reforms feel the real grouse is economic. For one of the most significant reforms being proposed is to entrust the appointments in government-aided schools with the state public service commission. At present, appointments are a lucrative cash cow for the managements (prevailing market rate for a high school teacher is more than Rs 12 lakh) even as the salaries are paid by the Government.

Some Hindu managements, like the Nair Service Society, have also objected to the reforms regarding appointments and administration being handed over to panchayats. The only major Hindu group which supports the reforms is Sree Narayana Dharma Paripalana (SNDP) Yogam, a lower caste Ezhavas' organisation. "The Government shouldn't buckle under pressure of the minorities and should go ahead with the reforms," says Vellappally Natesan, general secretary, SNDP. A few non-Catholic Christian groups, too, say there is nothing wrong in implementing social and economic justice in educational institutions. However, with the looming prospects of Lok Sabha elections next year, LDF, with its truncated image, looks in no mood to antagonise the powerful minorities further and the much-awaited reforms appear to be on their way to the cold storage. ■